

Who's in Charge?

Government Type and Coalition Command Structure

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Background

- ✦ **Coalitions:** a group of states facing a common threat or situation that coordinate military activities during a war, regardless of the nature of the pre-war relationship, with the goal of appeasing the shared threat (Morey 2016)
- ✦ **Coalitions $\neq$ Alliances**
Both are multilateral security cooperations, but coalitions require active military coordination whereas alliances can have broader purposes (Morey 2016).
- ✦ **Coalitions establish command structures** to determine who is in charge of developing and overseeing the coalition's military operations, which are carried out by all members' militaries (Morey 2016).
- ✦ There are **levels to command structures** that are decided upon by the members, based on how much control of their militaries they are willing to give up (Morey 2016).

Levels of Command

Parallel +least centralized command structure
+form a joint battle plan but execute it independently

Joint +single authority at the top making the operational decisions
+members' commanders form council that's in charge

Central +most centralized command
+members surrender control to individual

Theory

Pt. 1: Regime Type Similarity

Coalitions with members with similar regime types are more likely to opt for a stronger command structure (joint or central).

Pt. 2: Power Distribution of Coalition

Coalitions with a greater power disparity among members are likelier to opt for a stronger command structure (joint/centralized), where the weaker members cede power to the stronger states.

In coalitions where the power is distributed more evenly, the coalition command structure is determined by regime-type similarity.

H1: The larger the variance in regime types among members, the more likely the coalition will opt for a parallel command structure.

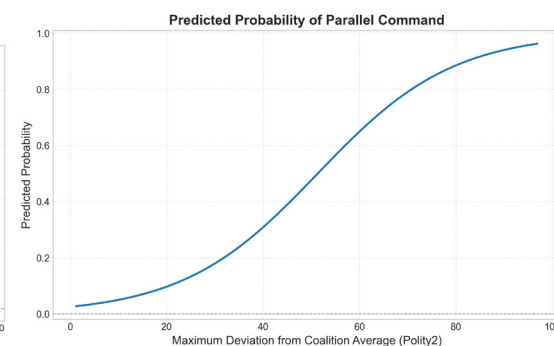
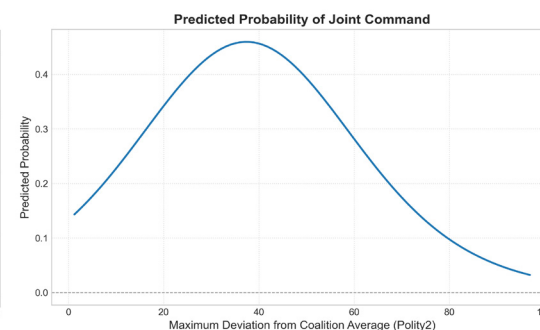
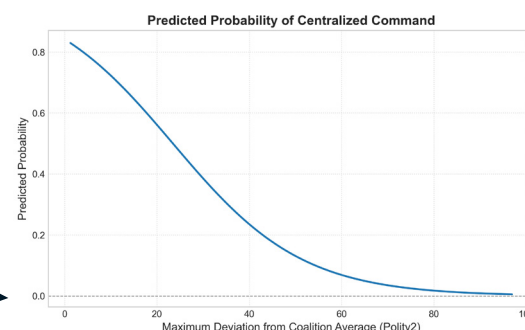
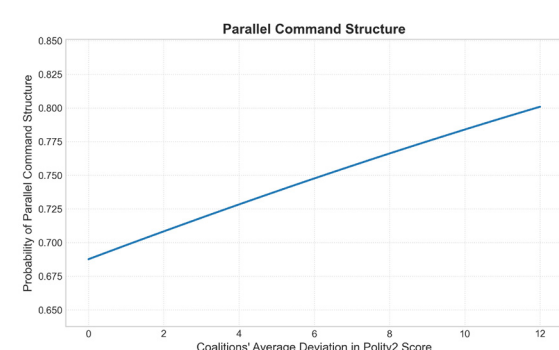
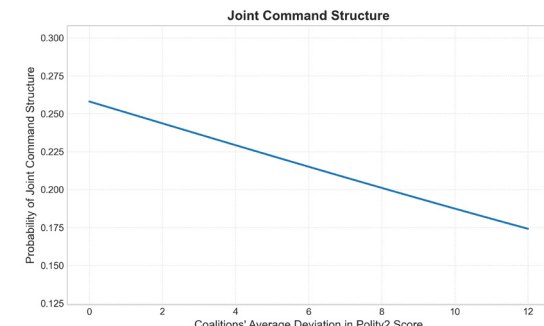
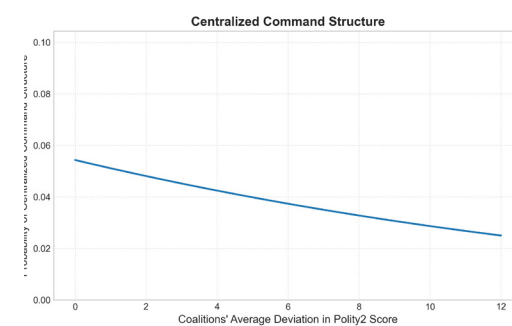
H2: Coalitions with similar regime types and evenly distributed power are likelier to opt for a joint command structure.

H3: Coalitions with different regime types and evenly distributed power are likelier to opt for a parallel command structure.

H4: Coalitions with unevenly distributed power are likelier to opt for a centralized command structure.

Model	Coefficient	P-value
Max Deviation	-0.073***	0.005
Outlier Dummy	-3.515***	0.001
Max Dev $\times$ Size	-0.103**	0.017

Model	Coefficient	P-value
Range per Member	-0.857***	0.002
Range Residuals	-0.238***	0.001
Polity2 SD	-0.280***	0.001



Future Research/Caveats

Future research into this topic could include taking coalition members' past fighting experience with each other into account or the treaties/alliance held among members

This project did not find that power was a significant factor in determining command structure, however the measure it used was CINC scores, so using a different measurement to capture power could yield different results.

Key Findings:

Political diversity drives decentralization:
Coalitions with greater internal regime variation are significantly more likely to adopt parallel or joint command structures.

Power and size do not predict command structure:
Power asymmetry, coalition size, and weighted democracy levels show weak or no significant effects.

Coalitions facing greater external threats are moderately more likely to centralize command authority.

References:

- Morey, Daniel S. "Military Coalitions and the Outcome of Interstate Wars." Foreign policy analysis 12, no. 4 (2016): 533–551.
- Morey, Daniel S. "Centralized Command and Coalition Victory." Conflict management and peace science 37, no. 6 (2020): 716–734.

Final Takeaway

Coalitions decentralize command not because of power imbalances or size, but because internal political differences — especially the presence of extreme regime types — create barriers to centralized authority.

Acknowledgments

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